

Geography of Colombian Life Satisfaction

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This paper is about geography of Colombian happiness.¹ We start with departments/provinces, then move to cities/municipalities, and finally finish up with urban-rural and farmers.

about colombia boilerplate like 2nd biggest land mas and pop in lat am? one of the happiest in the world:

Table 1: 10 happiest countries in the world. Data from World Database of Happiness (WDH) 2010-2019 out of 160 countries at worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl/rank-reports/satisfaction-with-life; and World Values Surveys (WVS) 2005-2022 [waves 5-7] out of 88 countries at <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org>. Technical information for WDH is at <https://worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl/reports/finding-reports-on-happiness-in-nations/technical-details-to-rank-reports-of-happiness-in-nations/technical-details-to-rank-report-average-happiness-in-nations-2010-2019> and WVS documentation is at <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org/WVSDocumentationWV7.jsp>.

WDH			WVS		
rank	country	happiness (1-10)	rank	country	happiness (1-10)
1	Denmark	8.2	1	Puerto Rico	8.4
2	Mexico	8.1	2	Mexico	8.3
3	Colombia	8.1	3	Colombia	8.3
4	Switzerland	8	4	Qatar	8.0
5	Finland	8	5	Norway	7.9
6	Iceland	8	6	Nicaragua	7.9
7	Costa Rica	7.9	7	Tajikistan	7.9
8	Norway	7.9	8	Switzerland	7.9
9	Canada	7.9	9	Uzbekistan	7.9
10	Qatar	7.8	10	Ecuador	7.8

and need about geography like goog 'gepgraphy of colombia' in goog scholar and normal goog

about roads etc ranked one of thw worst and airports

We know little about colombian happiness: my paper, stiupid burger as cited in my paper, and that govt report i cite in my paper!! do skim thru it!!

burger few observations: only few thousand (7-9k depending on model) and problematic measurement across space as elaborated in urb unhappiness is common

and there is interesting (Peiró-Palomino et al. 2020) but it uses an index objective indicators of quality of life such as income, housing and pollution.

There is a recent United Nations study on Colombian happiness using the same Encuesta Nacional de Calidad de Vida as we use, just earlier waves (PNUD 2023). The study is available from the the UN²

¹Following usual practice in social indicators research terms happiness and life satisfaction are used interchangeably, and specifically we mean cognitive and evaluative life satisfaction rather than affective happiness.

²https://www.undp.org/sites/g/files/zskgke326/files/2023-02/undp_co_pub_Percepciones_bienestar_subjetivo_2do_cuaderno_INDH_Feb21_2023.pdf.

It is closest to our study and most useful overview of Colombian happiness geography to date. There is in fact a similar map to ours in Figure 1.9 on page 26 for 2018-2021, but it is difficult to read as the colormap is undistinctive. While happy Cafetero agrees with our analysis, happy Narino does not. Likewise it finds Guaviare to be unhappy, while we find it moderately happy. A possible explanation for the differences is different timeframe: 2018-2021 theirs v 2023 and 2021 ours. Likewise in figure 1.10 they break down SWB by urban-rural, ours agrees that there is almost no difference, and in addition to urban-rural breakdown we add farmer-nonfarmer breakdown and add income breakdown for both.

1 Data

We use a great source of data ECV. We use 2023 edition. (and in appendix for robustness check 2021). Sampling details are at <https://microdatos.dane.gov.co/index.php/catalog/734>

The ECV is nationally representative, cross-sectional annual survey in Colombia, it includes about 250k persons and 80k households across rural and urban.³

It is representative of departments, but not municipalities, hence municipalities results are provisional.

The life satisfaction item reads: ?? and rural and farmer and money percapita

2 Departments/Provinces

there are 166k missing out of 242k, we conduct robustness check in appendix using 2021 wave

the map is below, table including number of observations per province is in appendix

unhappy: West (poor Choco, and Southern Cauca and Narino) and East Guainia and Vichada. In 2021 (see appendix) Choco and Cauca were still relatively unhappy, but slightly happier.

Happy Cafetero: Caldas, Risaralda, Quindio—in 2021 there were slight differences (see appendix) but overall Cafetero was happy too. And also happy Santander. Then slightly less happy Norte de Santander, Cesar and Atlantico. In 2021 (see appendix) Santander, Cesar and Atlantico were less happy.

³<https://www.dane.gov.co/index.php/estadisticas-por-tema/salud/calidad-de-vida-ecv/encuesta-nacional-de-calidad-de-vida-ecv-2021>

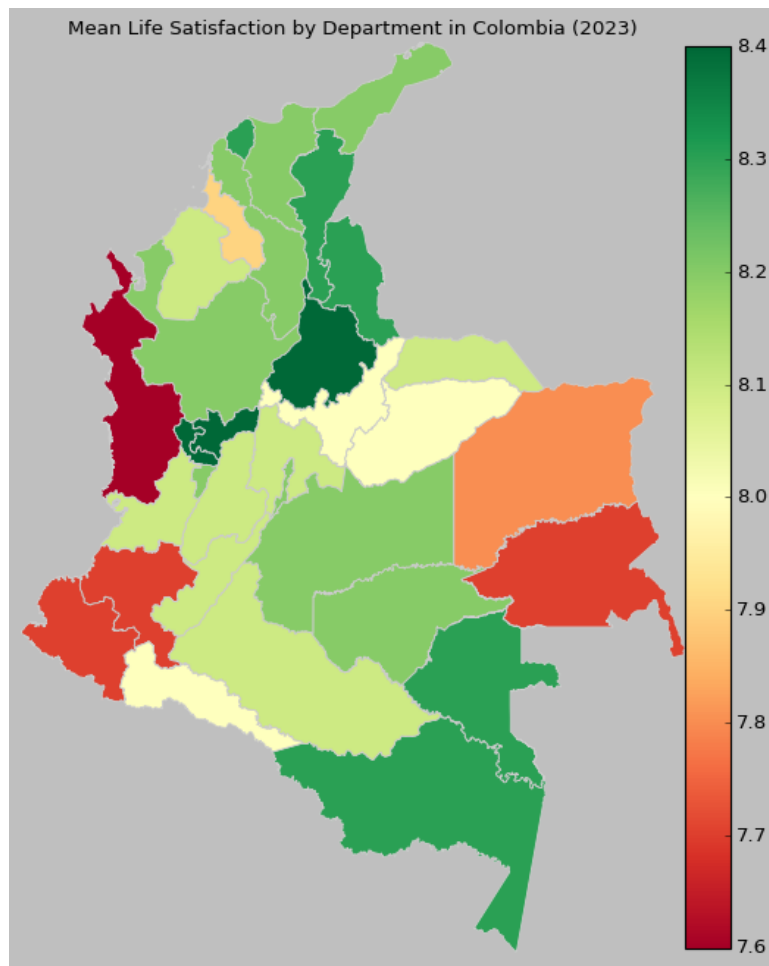


Figure 1: Similar to 2021 robustness/sensitivity check in appendix except: small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, both South-Eastern at 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Second largest differences: Santander and Putumayo increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

relatively unhappy caribbean cordoba and sucre, but then bolivar where caratgena is located is quite happy and so Atlantico where is Barranquilla, at least in 2023 (not so much in 2021).

3 Cities/Municipalities

166k/242k missing, again robustness/sensitivity check in appendix with 2021 ecv

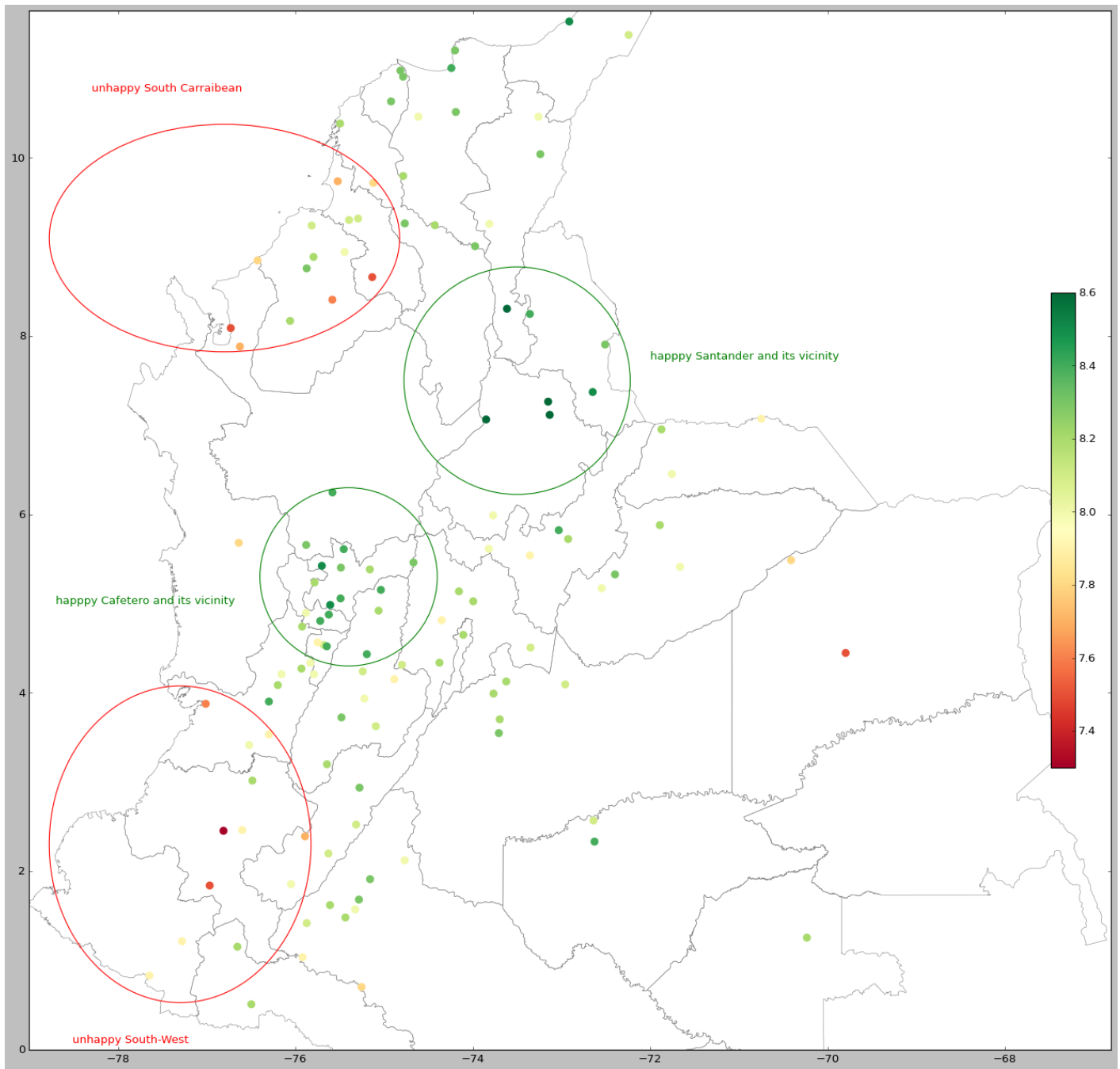


Figure 2: Zoom in to see the detail

Santander is one of the happiest departments, and so 2 santander largest cities shine: Bucaramanga and Barrancabermeja at 8.6. Bucaramanga was less happy in 2021 at 8.1. Another happy region Cafetero has many happy cities: Calarcá, Pereira, Manizales, and Armenia (Armenia was even happier in 2021). Other happy cities include 2nd largest Medellin, Ibaguë, and Ciénaga (Ciénaga was less happy in 2021 at 7.9). The least happy is remote Western Puerto Carreño at 7.5, and several cities at 7.9: Tunja, and Southern cities: Palmira in Valle de Cauca, Popayan in Cauca, and Pasto in Narino.

in 2021 results are similar, except that santander and its vicinity is less happy

4 Urban-Rural and Farmers

While most developed countries cities are unhappy and indeed unhappy city is a common pattern across the world (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021), it is not always the case in developing countries.

here boilerplate from happy col unahhpy bog: that cities are growth engines Glaeser (2011) and O'Sullivan (2009) and developing countries like colombia do need economic growth hence role for cities is gretaer than in already develpd countries

and there is paradox of happy peasant and unhappy millionaire Graham (2009)

though not so much in colombia, urban and rural are about same happy, except by income: bar chart by income category bu urb
rur as in raman

Both rural and farmer in figures ?? ??–there are slight differences, but overall similar pattern–no difference for the bottom and 9th deciles; rural and farmer happier in 2nd-8th deciles, and urban happier in the top decile. This makes sense, one needs money to enjoy city, where costof living is higher. In addition, life is more commodified in the city–one needs to pay for more things. For instance, many in the rural areas grow their own food. The bottom decile parity could be explained as that there is some minimum income necessary, and below it, it doesnt help to live in rural v urban area.

In other words, there are lower returns in happiness from income for rural (farmers) v urban persons (non-rarmers).

Overall, it is worth emphasizing that except the 1st decile and up to median and one decile above it–farmers/rural clearly happier.

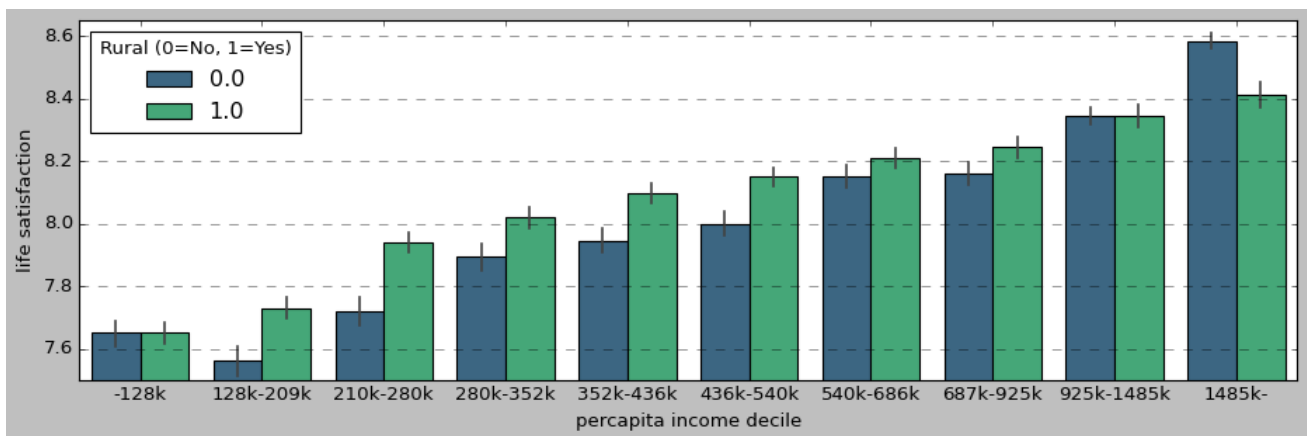


Figure 3

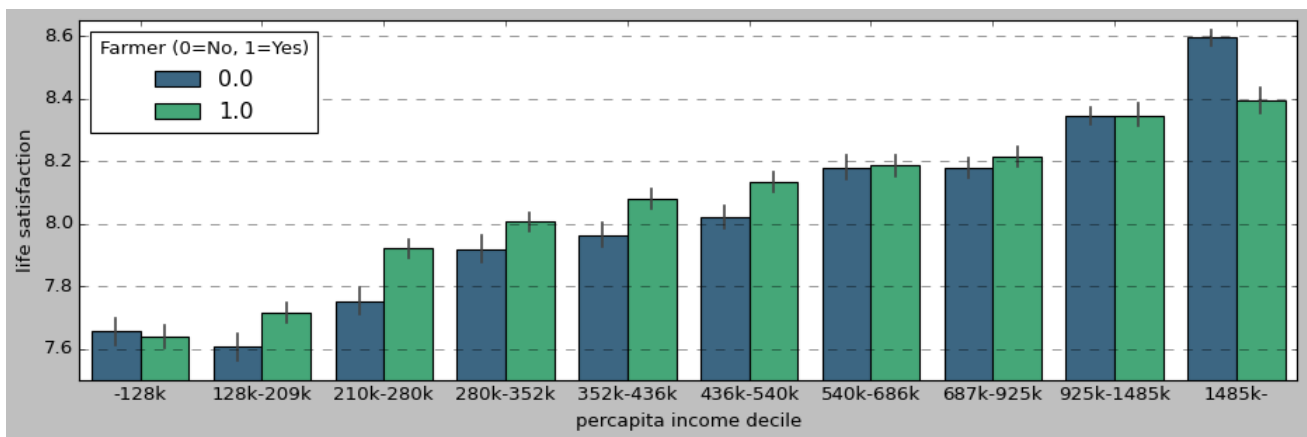


Figure 4

For rural in 2021 (appendix) pattern is similar but less strong for lower deciles where rural are happier than urban, but stronger for

2 top deciles where the opposite is true. For farmers in 2021 there is no happiness premium in lower deciles, but for non-farmers there is happiness premium in 2 top deciles.

ONLINE APPENDIX (Supplementary Online Material (SOM))

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead]

```
. tabstat ls, by(lwd7) stat(mean sd) format(%9.1f)
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Summary for variables: ls
Group variable: lwd7 (RECODE of lwd (do what you like))

lwd7	Mean	SD
0-4	5.6	2.7
2	7.6	2.3
3	7.6	1.8
4	8.0	1.5
5	7.8	1.9
6	8.2	1.5
7	8.9	1.5
Total	8.3	1.9

.9

5 Reestimation Using 2023 ECV

2021 May be biased say bc of covid, especially that it peaked in colombia in 2021 <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/region/colombia>(by 2023 used in the paper it pretty much cleared). But it a useful robustness check, if covid didnt change much , then it should be pretty stable

and it was quite high mortality in col <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/data/mortality>

5.1 Departments/Provinces

Again as said in the paper, overall results are similar to 2023 reported in the body of the paper, except both small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, South-Eastern and with 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Sencond largest differences are for Santander and Putumayo which increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

Table 2: Life satisfaction by department.

department	life satisfaction 2023	total 2023	obs	non-missing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	total 2021	obs	non-missing life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021
Amazonas	8.3	276		245	7.6	423		365	0.7
Antioquia	8.2	5499		4729	8.3	6036		5060	-0.1
Arauca	8.1	974		773	8.1	1103		868	0
Atlántico	8.3	3144		2311	8.0	2338		1799	0.3
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	4688		3446	8.1	5337		3810	0.1
Bolívar	8.2	2584		2258	8.1	2495		2156	0.1
Boyacá	8.0	4129		3649	7.8	4638		4122	0.2
Caldas	8.4	2822		2555	8.2	3335		3005	0.2
Caquetá	8.1	2547		2018	7.9	2846		2249	0.2
Casanare	8.0	1749		1370	8.1	2051		1457	-0.1
Cauca	7.7	2580		2244	7.9	2572		2287	-0.2
Cesar	8.3	2224		1717	8.0	1833		1510	0.3
Chocó	7.6	857		754	7.9	1016		913	-0.3
Cundinamarca	8.1	3818		3322	7.8	4233		3684	0.3
Córdoba	8.1	2706		2240	8.0	2226		1933	0.1
Guainía	7.7	327		273	7.4	350		274	0.3
Guaviare	8.2	700		457	8.0	621		411	0.2
Huila	8.1	2961		2322	8.0	2999		2407	0.1
La Guajira	8.2	951		750	7.9	988		736	0.3
Magdalena	8.2	2458		2096	8.0	2110		1710	0.2
Meta	8.2	3683		2752	8.1	3862		2817	0.1
Nariño	7.7	2284		2034	7.4	2847		2492	0.3
Norte de Santander	8.3	2499		2028	8.2	2587		2171	0.1
Putumayo	8.0	950		752	7.6	1272		1012	0.4
Quindío	8.2	2085		1658	8.4	2186		1785	-0.2
Risaralda	8.4	1634		1353	8.3	1996		1663	0.1
San Andrés y Providencia	8.4	28		25	8.2	29		26	0.2
Santander	8.4	3790		3194	8.0	4153		3574	0.4
Sucre	7.9	1798		1399	7.8	1899		1467	0.1
Tolima	8.1	3564		3215	8.0	4257		3770	0.1
Valle del Cauca	8.1	4892		4093	8.1	5268		4421	0
Vaupés	8.3	265		245	7.6	288		267	0.7
Vichada	7.8	515		455	7.6	584		482	0.2

5.2 Cities/Municipalities

Very important this robustness check because ECV is not representative of municipalities.

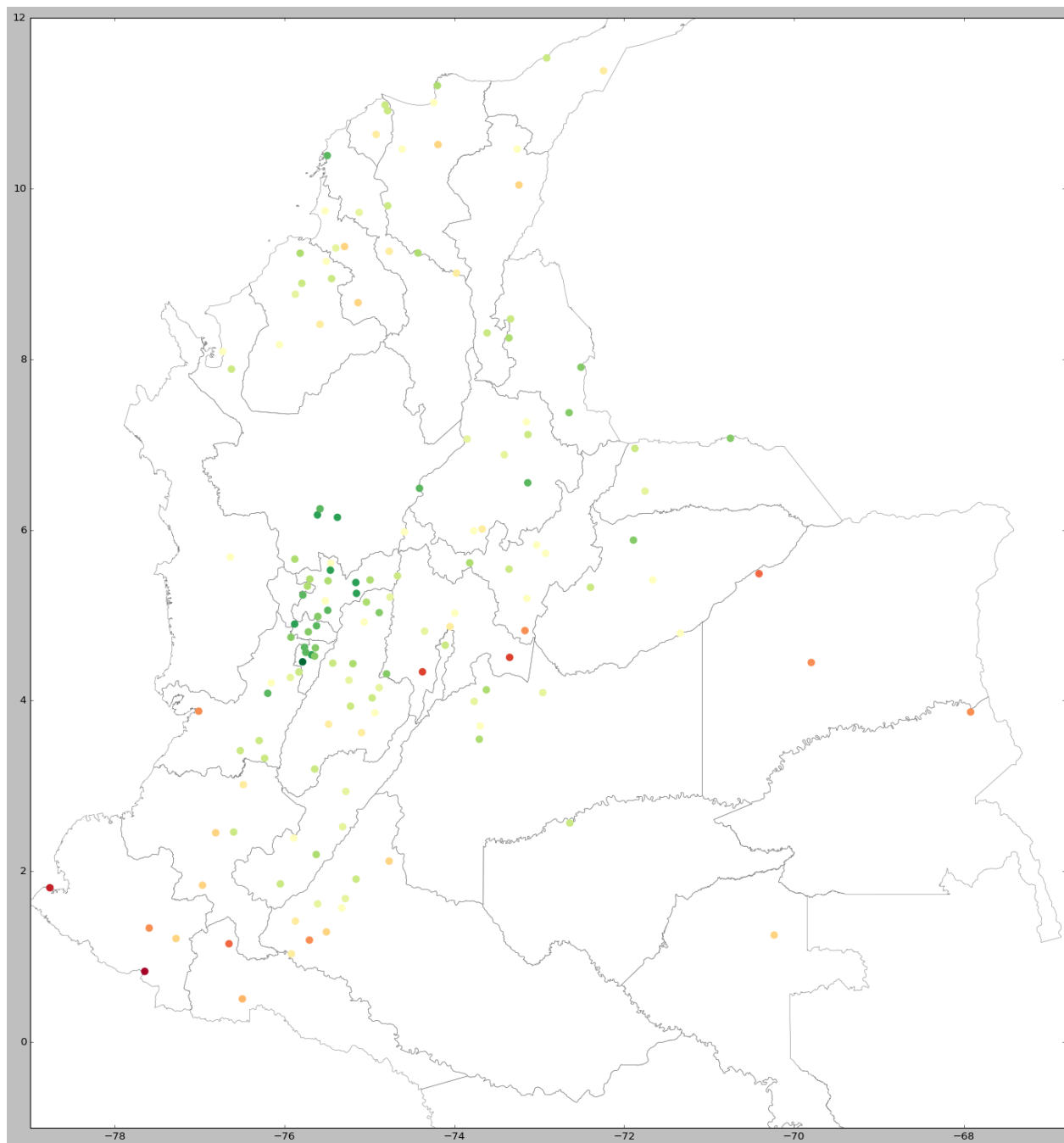


Figure 5: Zoom in to see the detail

Table 3: Life satisfaction by municipality, where non-missing on life satisfaction ¿200 or 220??

municipality name	mean life satisfaction 2023	non miss- ing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	non miss- ing life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021 diff
Buga	NaN	NaN	8.0	215	NaN
Espinal	NaN	NaN	7.8	220	NaN
Mariquita	NaN	NaN	7.9	201	NaN
Ocaña	NaN	NaN	8.2	200	NaN
San Vicente del Caguán	NaN	NaN	8.1	240	NaN
Armenia	8.1	668.0	8.5	681	-0.4
Buenaventura	8.1	412.0	8.3	279	-0.2
Cartagena	8.2	591.0	8.4	572	-0.2
Facatativá	8.1	200.0	8.3	222	-0.2
Palmira	7.9	319.0	8.1	332	-0.2
Popayán	7.9	225.0	8.1	232	-0.2
Tuluá	8.2	303.0	8.4	307	-0.2
Tunja	7.9	270.0	8.1	241	-0.2
Cali	8.0	985.0	8.1	1108	-0.1
Pitalito	8.0	293.0	8.1	288	-0.1
Cúcuta	8.3	573.0	8.3	553	0.0
Manizales	8.4	462.0	8.4	567	0.0
Medellín	8.4	905.0	8.4	959	0.0
Puerto Carreño	7.5	225.0	7.5	215	0.0
San José del Guaviare	8.1	246.0	8.1	231	0.0
Villavicencio	8.2	982.0	8.2	990	0.0
Acacías	8.3	229.0	8.2	233	0.1
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	3446.0	8.1	3836	0.1
Calarcá	8.4	244.0	8.3	257	0.1
Pereira	8.4	524.0	8.3	677	0.1
Santa Marta	8.3	225.0	8.2	218	0.1
Sincedejo	8.1	222.0	8.0	275	0.1
Valledupar	8.0	339.0	7.9	274	0.1
Barranquilla	8.3	1363.0	8.1	1116	0.2
Florencia	8.2	575.0	8.0	630	0.2
Ibagué	8.4	478.0	8.2	549	0.2
Pasto	7.9	244.0	7.7	309	0.2
Yopal	8.3	264.0	8.1	240	0.2
Montería	8.3	465.0	8.0	372	0.3
Neiva	8.3	417.0	8.0	436	0.3
Riosucio	8.5	203.0	8.2	203	0.3
Sogamoso	8.2	236.0	7.9	367	0.3
Aguachica	8.6	202.0	8.1	215	0.5
Bucaramanga	8.6	798.0	8.1	842	0.5
Ciénaga	8.4	234.0	7.9	252	0.5
Magangué	8.3	205.0	7.8	207	0.5

and here below ¿100

Table 4: Life satisfaction by municipality, where non-missing on life satisfaction ¿200 or 220??

municipality name	mean life satisfaction 2023	non-missing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	non-missing life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021 diff
Acacías	8.3	229.0	8.2	233.0	0.1
Aguachica	8.6	202.0	8.1	215.0	0.5
Aguadas	8.4	153.0	7.9	161.0	0.5
Aguazul	8.2	143.0	8.3	171.0	-0.1
Aguazul	8.0	102.0	8.3	171.0	-0.3
Aipe	8.1	112.0	8.0	100.0	0.1
Anserma	8.2	129.0	8.4	174.0	-0.2
Apartadó	8.3	119.0	8.2	111.0	0.1
Apartadó (Chigorodó)	7.8	132.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Aracataca	8.3	190.0	7.7	122.0	0.6
Arauca	7.9	199.0	8.3	199.0	-0.4
Armenia	8.1	668.0	8.5	681.0	-0.4
Ataco	NaN	NaN	8.3	101.0	NaN
Barichara	8.0	131.0	7.9	128.0	0.1
Barrancabermeja	8.6	270.0	8.0	199.0	0.6
Barranquilla	8.3	1363.0	8.1	1116.0	0.2
Bello	NaN	NaN	8.5	103.0	NaN
Bello (Copacabana)	NaN	NaN	8.5	103.0	NaN
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	3446.0	8.1	3836.0	0.1
Bosconia	8.3	106.0	7.7	124.0	0.6
Bucaramanga	8.6	798.0	8.1	842.0	0.5
Buenaventura	8.2	220.0	8.1	166.0	0.1
Buenaventura	8.0	192.0	8.1	166.0	-0.1
Buenaventura	8.2	220.0	8.3	279.0	-0.1
Buenaventura	8.0	192.0	8.3	279.0	-0.3
Buga	8.2	193.0	8.0	215.0	0.2
Cajibío	7.5	152.0	7.7	167.0	-0.2
Cajicá	NaN	NaN	7.8	106.0	NaN
Calamar	8.4	105.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Calarcá	8.4	244.0	8.3	257.0	0.1
Cali	8.0	985.0	8.1	1108.0	-0.1
Candelaria	8.0	113.0	7.9	154.0	0.1
Cartagena	8.2	591.0	8.4	572.0	-0.2
Cartagena del Chairá	8.1	120.0	7.8	136.0	0.3
Cartago	7.6	168.0	7.5	187.0	0.1
Cereté	8.2	131.0	8.1	109.0	0.1
Chaparral	NaN	NaN	7.9	108.0	NaN
Chinchiná	8.5	141.0	8.3	198.0	0.2
Chiquinquirá	8.4	128.0	7.9	152.0	0.5
Circasia	8.0	102.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Ciénaga	8.4	234.0	7.9	252.0	0.5
Codazzi	8.0	103.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Corozal	8.1	174.0	7.7	167.0	0.4
Coyaima	NaN	NaN	8.1	110.0	NaN
Curillo	7.9	103.0	7.8	123.0	0.1
Cúcuta	8.3	573.0	8.3	553.0	0.0
Cúcuta (El Zulia)	NaN	NaN	8.1	106.0	NaN
Dosquebradas	8.0	103.0	8.5	141.0	-0.5
Duitama	8.0	134.0	8.2	138.0	-0.2
El Carmen de Bolívar	7.8	200.0	8.0	167.0	-0.2
El Doncello	8.3	158.0	8.0	160.0	0.3
El Paujil	8.0	100.0	7.9	106.0	0.1
Envigado	7.7	146.0	8.1	180.0	-0.4
Espinal	8.3	170.0	7.8	220.0	0.5
Facatativá	8.1	200.0	8.3	222.0	-0.2
Flandes	7.9	135.0	8.0	195.0	-0.1
Florencia	8.2	575.0	8.0	630.0	0.2
Florida	8.4	119.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Fundación	8.3	200.0	7.8	155.0	0.5
Fusagasugá	8.2	156.0	7.3	117.0	0.9
Garagoa	NaN	NaN	7.9	109.0	NaN
Garzón	8.1	181.0	8.2	161.0	-0.1
Girardot	8.1	133.0	7.3	151.0	0.8
Granada	8.2	186.0	8.0	185.0	0.2
Guachené	7.3	138.0	7.7	161.0	-0.4
Guamo	NaN	NaN	8.1	106.0	NaN
Genova	NaN	NaN	8.3	101.0	NaN
Honda	NaN	NaN	8.0	102.0	NaN
Ibagué	8.4	478.0	8.2	549.0	0.2
Inírida	7.8	102.0	7.4	120.0	0.4
Inírida	7.8	102.0	7.5	149.0	0.3
Ipiales	7.9	137.0	7.1	134.0	0.8
Itagüí	NaN	NaN	8.4	128.0	NaN
Jamundí	NaN	NaN	8.1	103.0	NaN
La Calera	8.2	105.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
La Dorada	8.3	189.0	8.1	197.0	0.2
La Montañita	8.2	106.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
La Plata	7.7	133.0	7.9	128.0	-0.2
La Tebaida	NaN	NaN	8.7	113.0	NaN
Lorica	8.1	201.0	8.2	150.0	-0.1
Líbano	8.4	116.0	8.2	113.0	0.2
Magangué	8.3	205.0	7.8	207.0	0.5
Maicao	8.1	167.0	7.8	162.0	0.3
Malambo	8.3	234.0	7.8	136.0	0.5
Manizales	8.4	462.0	8.4	567.0	0.0
Manzanares	NaN	NaN	7.9	103.0	NaN
Mariquita	8.2	173.0	7.9	201.0	0.3
Marmato	NaN	NaN	8.5	121.0	NaN
Marulanda	NaN	NaN	8.5	100.0	NaN
Medellín	8.4	905.0	8.4	959.0	0.0
Mitú	8.2	173.0	7.7	181.0	0.5
Mocoa	8.2	112.0	7.4	128.0	0.8
Mompós	8.2	124.0	8.2	135.0	0.0
Montenegro	7.9	146.0	8.4	176.0	-0.5
Montería	8.3	465.0	8.0	372.0	0.3
Morelia	NaN	NaN	7.7	111.0	NaN
Natagaima	8.1	103.0	7.8	102.0	0.3
Neira	8.2	109.0	8.5	114.0	-0.3
Neiva	8.3	417.0	8.0	436.0	0.3
Ocaña	8.4	182.0	8.2	200.0	0.2
Paipa	NaN	NaN	7.9	104.0	NaN
Palmira	7.9	319.0	8.1	332.0	-0.2
Pamplona	8.5	130.0	8.3	116.0	0.2
Pasto	7.9	244.0	7.7	309.0	0.2
Paz de Ariporo	NaN	NaN	7.9	113.0	NaN
Pereira	8.4	524.0	8.3	627.0	0.1

5.3 Urban-Rural and Farmers

Colombia is quite urbanized at around 70-80%. <https://population.un.org/wup/countryprofiles?country=Colombia&mainCategory=Countries%20and%20Aggregates&subCategory=Urbanization%20-%20International%20definition>

Still, a substantial part at 20-30% is rural.

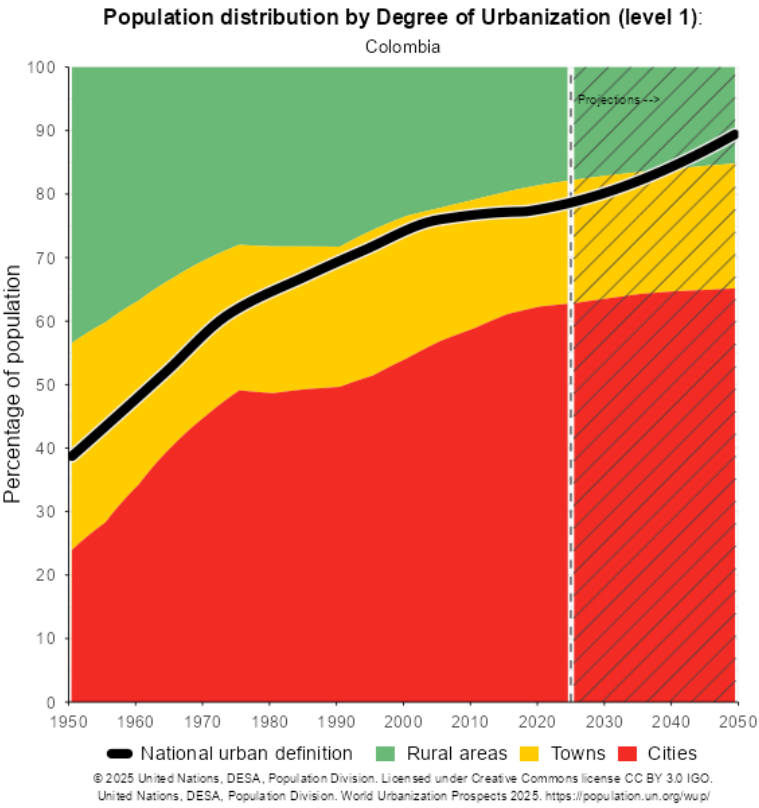


Figure 6

For rural in 2021 pattern is similar to 2023 in body of the paper but less strong for lower deciles where rural are happier than urban, but stronger for 2 top deciles where the opposite is true. For farmers in 2021 there is no happiness premium in lower deciles, but for non-farmers there is happiness premium in 2 top deciles.

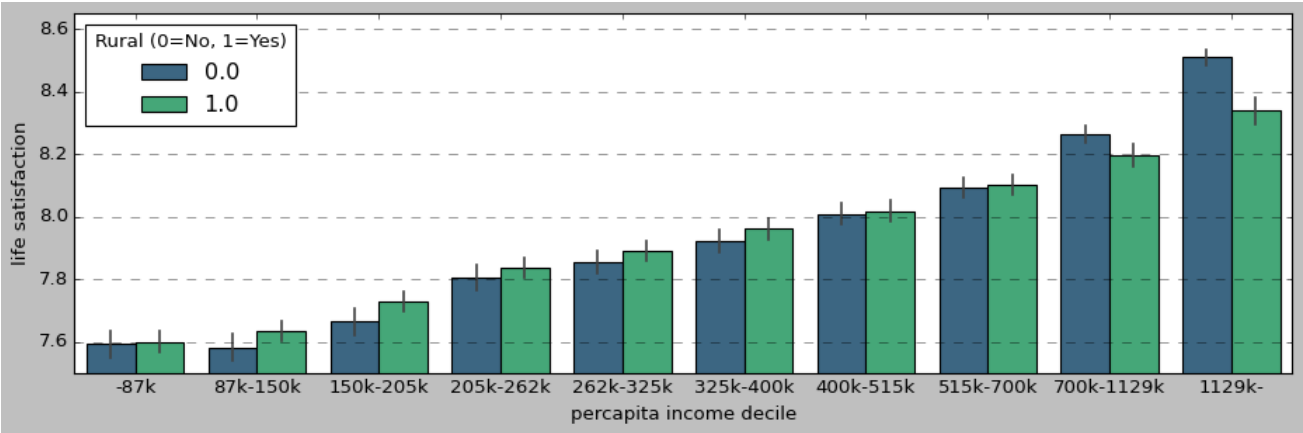


Figure 7

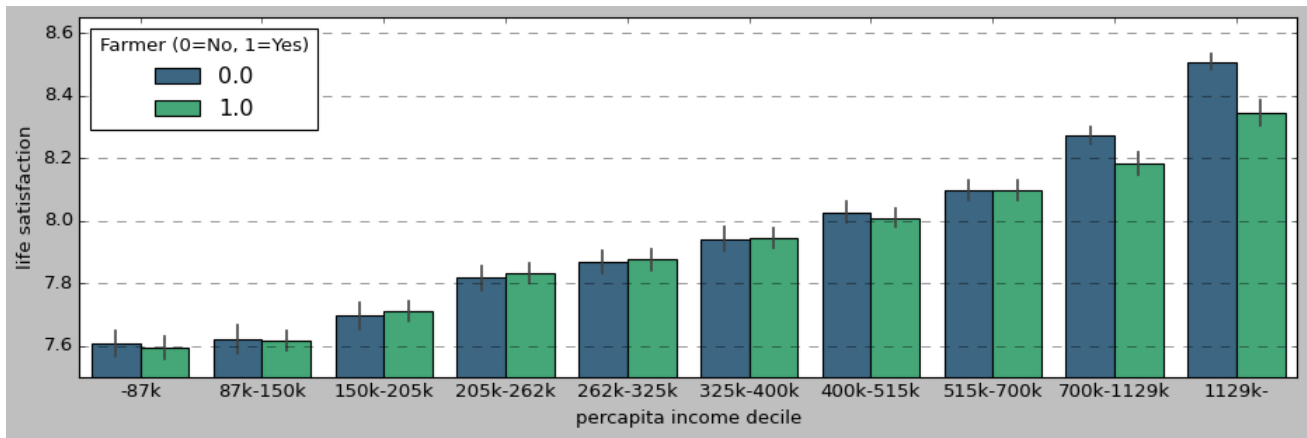


Figure 8

5.4 Geography of Colombia

The paper is about geography of happiness, but it would be incomplete without some mention of geography. First map of departments in figure ??.

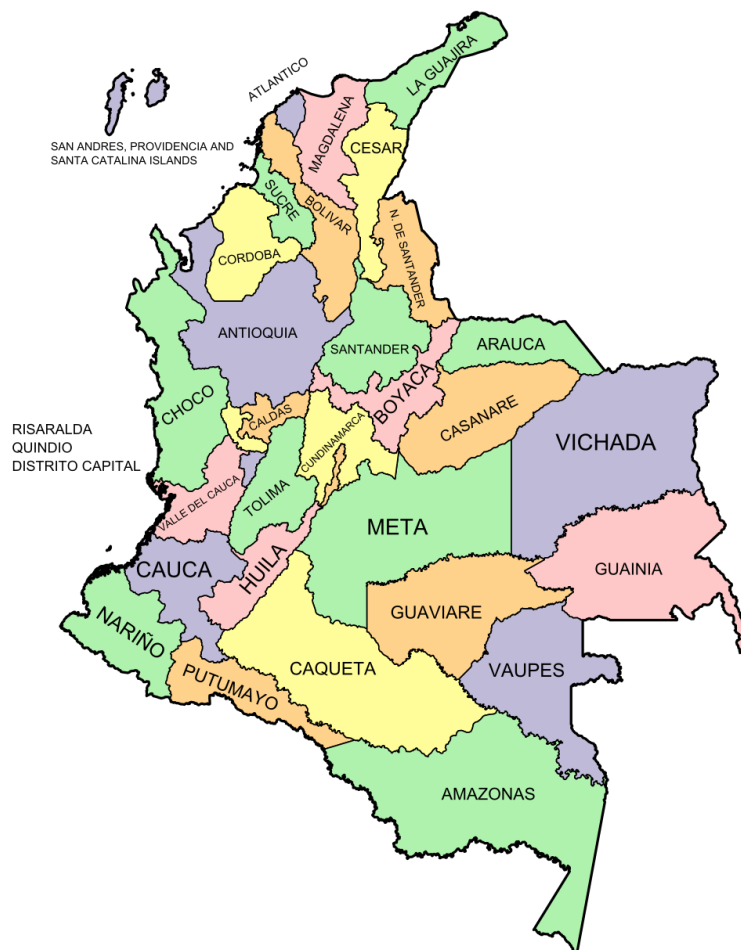


Figure 9: Colombia departments. Source: https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/thumb/6/67/Departments_of_colombia.svg/960px-Departments_of_colombia.svg.png.

Topography is well mapped and best viewed at [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Mapa_de_Colombia_\(relieve\).svg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Mapa_de_Colombia_(relieve).svg),

where you can zoom in to see the detail.

Population is nicely visualized in a 3d map at <https://geoportal.dane.gov.co/geovisores/sociedad/grilla-dane-vihope/>.

Land use is shown in ??—note that most of the country is still natural.

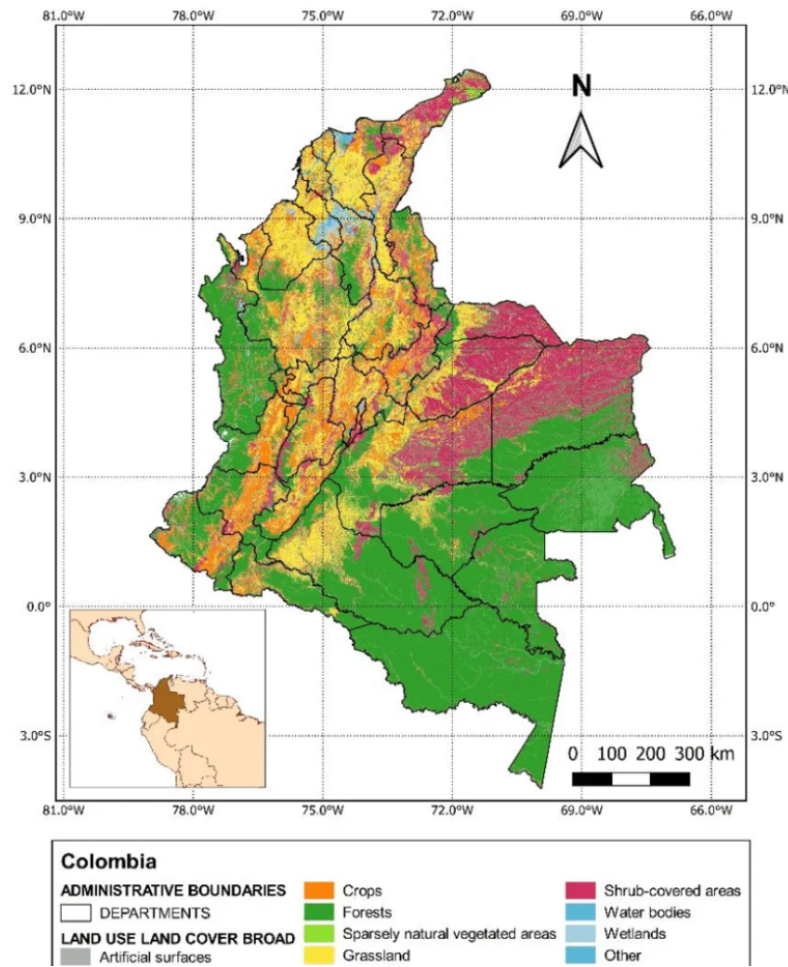


Figure 10: Land use. Source: https://www.researchgate.net/figure/Land-use-and-land-cover-map-of-Colombia-2012_fig3_346648643.

Likewise there is a lot of biomass in natural areas (and non-desert and not frozen) in figure ??.

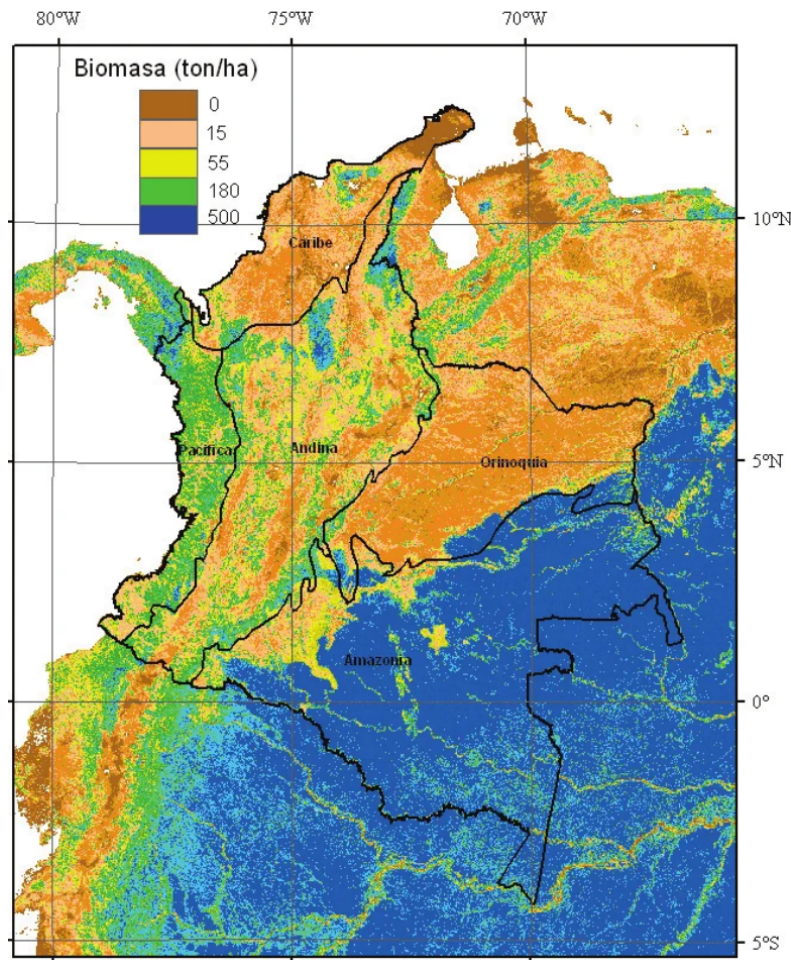


Figure 11: Biomass. Source: Anaya, J. A., Chuvieco, E., & Palacios, A. (2008). Estimación de biomasa aérea en Colombia a partir de imágenes MODIS. *Revista de Teledetección*, 30, 5-22. https://www.researchgate.net/figure/Figura-7-Distribucion-espacial-de-valores-promedio-de-biomasa-en-Colombia_fig4_255626661.

Last but not least ecological footprint. <https://data.footprintnetwork.org/> is a useful global overview, Colombian footprint per person is quite low at 2gha, 4x lower than that of the US at 8 gha, and it is stable since 1960s, but biocapcity per person has declined from 11.4 gha in 1960 to 3.3 in 2024. <https://happyplanetindex.org/countries/COL/> is another tool for cross-country comparisons.

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1470160X20305677> provides useful hi-resolution visualizations of footprint across Colombia 1970-2015.

OECD provides more recent update across Colombia: https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-environmental-performance-968398f7-en/full-report/biodiversity-conservation-and-sustainable-use_2099ac2c.html

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